



Tips & Tricks



Encryption with VIM

Editor's note: Last month we showcased a tip on how to encrypt a file using Vim. One of our readers had, in fact, sent a more detailed tip around the same time, which we have published this month.

Create an encrypted file called *abc.txt*

```
[prabhat@localhost ~]$ vim -x abc.txt
```

This will prompt you to enter an encryption key (password) before creating the new *abc.txt* file.

```
Enter encryption key:***
```

```
Enter same key again:***
```

After entering the passphrase twice, the *abc.txt* file will finally be opened for entering data. Key in a few characters/words/sentences, then save and close the file.

Now try to read the file as you would with a typical command like *cat*:

```
[prabhat@localhost ~]$ cat abc.txt
```

```
VimCrypt-01R8BW
```

```
b
```

```
Eg[prabhat@localhost ~]$
```

Did you notice that although you're the owner of the file, you yourself can't even read it without using the passphrase.

Go ahead and check the ownership and file permissions yourself, as follows:

```
[prabhat@localhost ~]$ ls -l abc.txt
```

```
-rw-rw-r-- 1 prabhat prabhat 33 Apr 12 00:07 abc.txt
```

Here's how you can check if this file has been corrupted or encrypted:

```
[prabhat@localhost ~]$ file abc.txt
```

```
abc.txt: Vim encrypted file data
```

It means it's not corrupt, but encrypted. Now to open the file, issue the following command:

```
[prabhat@localhost ~]$ vim abc.txt
```

You will be asked to enter the password for this file, that's it.

Now, how about changing this password? Let's say that earlier it was 123 and now we want to change it to 777. Here we go:

```
[prabhat@localhost ~]$ vim +X abc.txt
```

```
Enter encryption key:***
```

```
"abc.txt" [encrypted] 1L, 21C
```

```
Enter encryption key:***
```

```
Enter same key again:***
```

It's mandatory to save and quit, otherwise your new password will not be saved. So now your new password, 777, is set. Next time make sure you entered this new password while opening *abc.txt*.

Finally, how can we remove the password or encryption from file? Simple... Run the following command:

```
[prabhat@localhost ~]$ vim +X abc.txt
```

Open a file with your password and it will ask you to enter new encryption. Don't enter anything, but just hit the *Enter* key twice, followed by a *Save* and *Quit*. That's it! Now you can open your file without a password.

—Prabhat Rishi, prabhatrishi@rediffmail.com



Seven ways to log out of Bash

How many ways do you know of to log out from a Bash shell? Here are at least seven commands that you may use to log out—but please be aware that some of the commands are dangerous if you're logged in as the root user because they could stop services/daemons that usually run as the root.